

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

The World Health Organisation declared an **Ebola** outbreak in Congo and Uganda a “public health emergency of international concern”. The UN health agency said that it suspected [the virus](#) had infected 250 people and killed 80 more in regions along the border between the two countries. America’s Centres for Disease Control and Prevention said it is trying to contain and track the virus at its centres in Africa.

Iran reportedly shared an updated set of terms for ending the war with **America**. Earlier **Donald Trump** said that the “clock is ticking” for Iran to agree to a deal, which is being [negotiated](#) through Pakistani mediators. If Iran did not “get moving”, there would not “be anything left of them”, Mr Trump warned, adding that “TIME IS OF THE ESSENCE”.

Sir Keir Starmer, Britain’s prime minister, will not set a timetable to resign, said David Lammy, his deputy. Mr Lammy insisted that it was time for **Labour** to “get back on the pitch” after days of “infighting”. Meanwhile [Wes Streeting](#), who resigned as health secretary, said he would challenge [Andy Burnham](#), Greater Manchester’s mayor and another hopeful, in any [leadership contest](#).

Volodymyr Zelensky, **Ukraine's** president, said his country's latest wave of drone strikes, which killed three people in the Moscow region, was "entirely justified". It appeared to be Ukraine's biggest [such operation](#) since the start of the war. **Russia** said it intercepted more than 500 drones across 14 regions and occupied Crimea. Mr Zelensky cited a Russian assault on Kyiv, Ukraine's capital, on Thursday that killed 24 people.

The White House said that **China** had agreed to buy at least \$17bn-worth of **American agricultural goods** each year until 2028. China made the commitment during Mr Trump's [visit to Beijing](#) last week, according to the White House. China has not yet confirmed the figure. The purchases would be a relief for [America's farmers](#).

Spain's conservative People's Party won a local election in Andalusia, the country's most populous region, but lost its majority there. It will now probably need to form a coalition with **Vox**, a [populist-right party](#). Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's Socialist Party suffered a crushing defeat in the poll, which was a final test before a general election due by August 2027.

French authorities said that around ten previously unknown potential victims of **Jeffrey Epstein**, a dead sex offender, had come forward. Laure Beccuau, the head of Paris' public prosecutor's office, said that officials would gather testimonies from the alleged victims. Ms Beccuau said investigators are also scouring [files](#) released by America's Justice Department.

Figure of the day: 3%, the percentage of Russia's pre-war male population of fighting age thought to have been killed or wounded in the war in Ukraine. [Read about](#) Russia losing ground in the conflict.



Photograph: Getty Images

Preparing for the next pandemic

It is a grim time for global health. Cuts by the Trump administration to America's aid budget have stripped billions of dollars from health programmes and could cause more than 14m deaths over the next five years, according to one study. Against this backdrop, senior health officials from around the world will meet in Geneva on Monday for a six-day conference that will decide the World Health Organisation's priorities.

One big issue is the impasse over the pandemic treaty, which was drawn up to improve how countries work together during outbreaks. It is being held up by disagreements over how data on pathogens are to be shared. Developing countries want guarantees of access to novel medicines, such as vaccines; richer countries want a more flexible system that gives pharmaceutical companies and university researchers greater control over their intellectual property. Recent outbreaks of [deadly hantavirus](#) on a cruise ship and Ebola in the Democratic Republic of Congo have underscored the urgency of reaching an agreement.



Photograph: Eyevine

The Gulf war batters South-East Asia

When the war in the Gulf began, South-East Asian countries, which rely heavily on Middle Eastern oil, were among the first to react. The Philippines declared a national “energy emergency”; Thailand issued work-from-home orders and other demand-destroying measures. GDP in the Philippines grew by just 2.8% year on year in the first quarter of 2026, its weakest pace since the pandemic—even though just one month of the three was impacted. The figure is a harbinger for the region.

On Monday Thailand reported that its GDP grew by 2.8% year on year in the first quarter, above estimates but still below the government’s target of over 3% for 2026. Tourism, which accounts for a sixth of Thai GDP, is being squeezed by higher air fares. Manufacturers are complaining of costlier inputs. Most worrying, farmers are cutting back planting plans for the coming paddy season as fuel and fertiliser costs rise. For South-East Asia, the war-induced pain may only [just be beginning](#).



Photograph: AP

Israel is about to call an election

This week the Knesset, Israel's parliament, is expected to dissolve itself and start the countdown to elections. The immediate trigger is a demand by ultra-Orthodox parties in the ruling coalition for a law exempting students in religious seminaries from compulsory military service. Binyamin Netanyahu, the prime minister, was willing to pass the legislation, but failed to muster the necessary votes. The ultra-Orthodox parties therefore withdrew their support for the coalition.

Surprisingly, the government has almost completed its four-year term, a rare feat in Israel. It was widely criticised for failing to anticipate Hamas's massacre on October 7th 2023. But in the aftermath Mr Netanyahu not only kept his coalition of nationalist and religious parties together, he also persuaded others to join the government as it prepared for war. Fighting in Gaza has left the territory devastated and fragmented, with control divided between Israeli forces and Hamas. The war there, along with Israel's campaigns in Lebanon and Iran, will loom large in the coming election.



Photograph: 6th Air Refueling Wing

Special-operations forces gather in Florida

On Monday an annual convention for the international special-operations community kicks off in Tampa, Florida. Commanders and commandos from America and its allies will talk shop; around 850 companies will exhibit. Palantir, the leader of [a new clique of defence upstarts](#) that are reimagining how to wage war, is among them.

The mood, though, will be mixed. America's special-operations forces have recently pulled off some spectacular stunts, including the capture of Venezuela's strongman, Nicolas Maduro, in January. But they have had a flat budget since 2019, resulting in a 14% drop in purchasing power. The Pentagon has trimmed personnel by nearly 3,000 since 2022, leaving a force of 70,000. Yet Donald Trump increasingly turns to them to execute his foreign policy. In March commanders warned Congress of "unsustainable demand". This week's convention will amount to a call for reinforcements.



Photograph: MEGA Agency

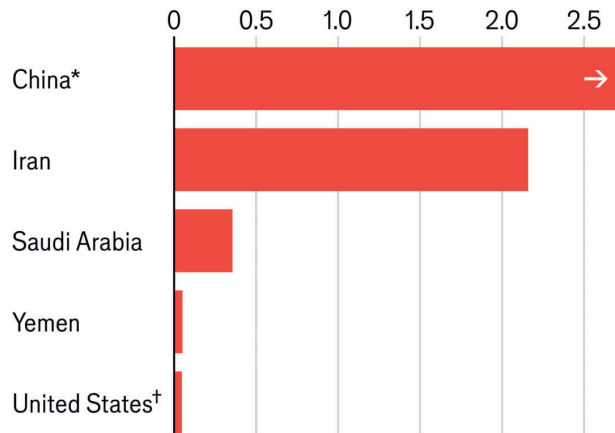
A grim record for executions

On Monday Amnesty International published its annual tally of capital punishment. In 2025 at least 2,707 executions took place worldwide, a 78% rise from 2024 and most since 1981. Iran alone accounted for four-fifths of them. The figures exclude China, which is thought to be the world's leading executioner but classifies death-penalty data as a state secret, as well as North Korea and Vietnam.

More than 140 countries have abolished the death penalty. In one that hasn't, Japan, it may now at least be easier to free those wrongly convicted. The country has a 99% conviction rate and prosecutors can appeal against almost any decision to reopen a case, making successful retrials for defendants highly unusual: in 2024 [a death-row prisoner was exonerated](#) after 46 years. On Friday Japan's cabinet approved a bill that would in effect ban such appeals. Nevertheless, Japan shows no sign of ending capital punishment.

License to kill

Minimum estimated number of executions, '000, 2025



*Amnesty International estimates there have been thousands of executions in China

†Actual figure

Source: Amnesty International



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which martial artist from Hong Kong had a Hollywood hit with the film “Rush Hour”?

*You can no more win a war than
you can win an earthquake.*

Jeannette Rankin